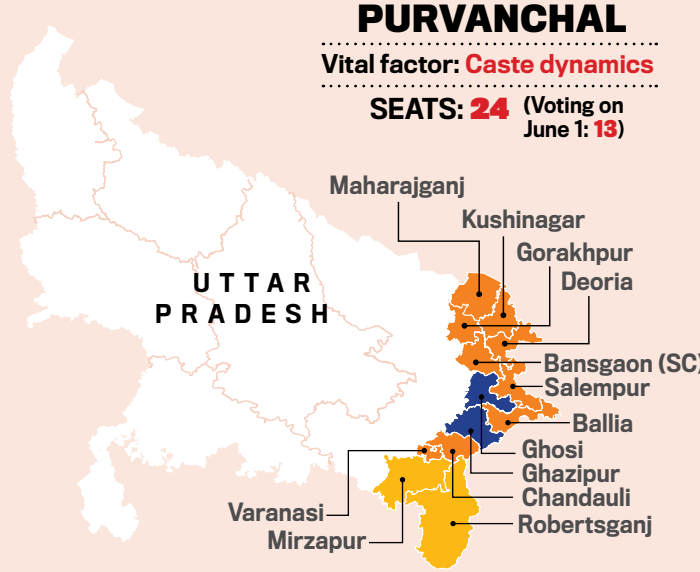


PURVANCHAL

Vital factor: Caste dynamics

SEATS: 24 (Voting on June 1: 13)



2019 LOK SABHA RESULTS

BJP AD(S) BSP SP Cong. Others

The BJP's smaller allies will play a big role here. Gorakhpur is also the home base of CM Yogi Adityanath. In 2019, the BJP had lost the Ghosi, Ghazipur, Ambedkar Nagar and Lalganj seats here. The poverty-stricken region has got big-ticket investments in the past five years and the BJP is betting on that and government scheme benefits to help them out.

Key contests: In Varanasi, PM Narendra Modi takes on UP Congress president Ajay Rai. The BJP is focussed on increasing Modi's victory margin, though the Congress claims its won't be so easy this time. In Ghazipur, the SP has fielded Afzal Ansari, brother of the late gangster-turned-neta Mukhtar Ansari in the first poll after his death.

AN EPIC IN SEVEN CHAPTERS COMES to a close on June 1, proceeding left to right on the map—like words on a page. The ink will reveal itself a mere three days later, but it is Purvanchal's privilege to get in the last word there. The 13 Lok Sabha seats of the far eastern belt of Uttar Pradesh are voting at the fag-end of a long-drawn electoral process that began setting its patterns right from the first phase on April 19. By and large, modest turnouts were seen across the first six phases when compared to 2019. Whether that trend continues may carry no material relevance to eventual outcomes in a star constituency like Varanasi, where Prime Minister Narendra Modi is seeking a third term. But elsewhere, including in the Gorakhpur region, home turf of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, it will surely be part of the overall story, and perhaps one of its constitutive elements.

Both Varanasi in the south and Gorakhpur up north are bastions for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), but Purvanchal as a whole is characterised better by a parallel fact: this is a zone where the ruling party is heavily dependent on its smaller allies—the Om Prakash Rajbhar-led Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), the Sanjay Nishad-led Nirbal Indian Shoshit Hamara Aam Dal (NISHAD) party, and the Anupriya Patel-led Apna Dal (Sonelal) or AD(S). The Modi and Yogi factors remain ever-present, but what these three allies bring to the party—the vital votes from their specific niches in the Other Backward Classes (OBC) spectrum—will be crucial. The question, this time, attends to both sides, but flows from the same premise: the set of national questions that confront the BJP, which seem to have created a mood